Netherlands 2026

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John Cable, 25th February 2026.

Introduction 3

Before We Go..... 4

The Trip 14

Appendix 1 – Personal Packing Checklist 21

Appendix 2 – Best Hot Chocolate Cafes in Amsterdam 24

Appendix 3 – Potential Day Trips 27

Introduction

In 2026, we are going on a short trip to the Netherlands to see the sights of Amsterdam and to day-trip to Keukenhof to see the tulips. This eBook is a guide to help us prepare for the trip.

As for previous eBooks, this eBook is divided into 3 main sections, namely:

- Stuff to do before we go,
- The trip itself, and
- Coming home at the end

If I think of any other stuff I'll put it into appendices at the end. So, without further ado, let's crack on!

Before We Go

Well, before we start our trip, there are a few things to think about and do. I have split these up as follows:

- Background: why we are going at this time of year, weather, distances etc.
- Health: what we need to do before we go (in terms of innoculations, tablets etc.)
- Travel: what our outbound long–haul flight details are, any considerations about time left on passports etc.
- Money: what the local currency is, advice from journey planners re use of credit cards etc.
- Miscellaneous: duty free precautions, electrical supply etc.

I have also included as an Appendix what I envisage packing for the trip (excluding clothing - I am sure you can make up your own minds about clothing!).

Background

We are visiting the Netherlands in mid to late April so we can catch the 'tulip season' – a very popular tourist time of year for foreign tourists and for the Dutch themselves.

Weather

The weather in the Netherlands for the time of our trip is very similar to UK weather – quite cool with some rainfall, best sums it up. So, not hot and occasional nights when overnight temperatures are cold. Take decent overnight gear and a light waterproof for showers is my best advice. Layers will be the order of the day.

Spring in the Netherlands coincides with what most of us think of as spring, spanning March through May. Temperatures are warm across most of the country, but it isn't yet too hot or too humid.

What to Pack: During spring in the Netherlands, temperatures are still cold. You'll want to dress in layers, as well as carry a light jacket and scarf. In early spring, a heavier coat will still be necessary for some parts of the country.

Amsterdam has a very similar climate to the UK, with mild summers and cool winters. In April, you can expect average high temperatures around 12-15°C (54-59°F) and average lows around 3-6°C (37-43°F). Rain is also common in April, so it's advisable to bring a waterproof jacket or umbrella.

Population and Geography

The Netherlands is a country of approx. 18.45 million people and nearly 41,850 square kilometres in size. It is a very flat country with about one-third of the country lies below sea level, with extensive polders, dikes, and coastal dunes.. The Netherlands is famous for its canals, tulip fields, windmills and cycling routes. The capital city is Amsterdam, which is known for its artistic heritage, elaborate canal system and narrow houses with gabled facades. Other major cities include Rotterdam, The Hague and Utrecht.

Our holiday will be almost exclusively centred on Amsterdam.

Health

Do check with your GP about what innoculations they advise for your personal circumstances for this trip. They will normally check for whether you are up to date with vaccines for cholera, typhoid, Hepatitis A and Tetanus.

Make sure and get them to bring your vaccination record card up to date and store it somewhere safe.

Hampton GP surgery also gave me two web sites to check:

- National Travel Health Network and Centre , and
- Fit For Travel

From those web sites for the Netherlands: travellers should be up to date with routine vaccination courses and boosters as recommended in the UK. These vaccinations include for example measles-mumps-rubella (MMR) vaccine and diphtheria-tetanus-polio vaccine. There are no specific health risks in the Netherlands, and no special precautions are needed for travellers. There is no risk of malaria or other mosquito-borne diseases in the Netherlands. The Netherlands has a good standard of healthcare, and there are no specific health risks for travellers.

However, it is always advisable to have travel insurance that covers medical expenses when travelling abroad.

Travel

The Netherlands is in a different time zone to the UK - they are 1 hour in front of us.

Your passport should be valid for the proposed duration of your stay. No additional period of validity beyond this is required. There should be at least 2 completely blank pages left in your passport as well.

Air Journey	Distance (miles)
Birmingham to Amsterdam 9th April Flight **KLM 1042** from Birmingham to Amsterdam Depart: 0920, Arrive: 1130	276
Amsterdam to Birmingham 14th April Flight **KLM 1047** from Amsterdam to Birmingham Depart: 1635, Arrive: 1650	276
TOTAL air miles	276

From the airport we will take the Sprinter to Amsterdam Centraal and then walk to Centraal Station to pick up the number 14 bus to the Artis/Holocaust Museum and the hotel is a two-minute walk from there.

Money

The Netherlands has the Euro (€) as its unit of currency.

The Netherlands is pretty high-tech, so we may only need to take a small amount of Euros in cash. As with any holiday abroad, you are recommended to let your bank know that you will be using your card(s) in the Netherlands before you leave, if that is what you intend to do.

Credit cards (and pre-paid credit cards such as FairFX) shoiuld be accepted for most things in the Netherlands e.g. train tickets, hotels incl. Apple pay.

Miscellaneous

Duty Free Precautions

Nothing special here except it says there is a 50ml max on perfume being brought into the Netherlands (incl. gents after shave and spray, and eau-de-toilette)

On the return to the UK, these are selected allowances:

- Up to 18 litres of wine (not sparkling)
- Up to 4 litre of spirits over 22% aolcohol, or
- Up to 9 litres of sparkling wine, fortified wine (for example port, sherry) and other alcoholic drinks up to 22% alcohol (not including beer or still wine)

Wifi and Phones

In the Netherlands, free wifi is widely available. Access is usually provided as a wireless network or wired internet via LAN cable in hotels. In addition, many cafes, restaurants and bars offer free wifi for customers.

Check with your mobile phone contract as to any additions you may need or want to consider when going to the Netherlands - I'm not predicting having to purchase any such additions for myself.

Electricity

The voltage in the Netherlands is 230 Volts, same as the UK. Socket tytpes C and F are used there so we will need to take our travel adapters.

Type C Socket

Type F Socket

So we will need travel adapters – the existing blue travel adaptors MAY be OK. – so we can have our 4-way blocks plugged in at our accommodation.

Accommodation

While in Amsterdam, we will be staying at the Leonardo Boutique Lancaster Hotel, Plantage Middenlaan 48, 1018 DH Amsterdam, Netherlands. We have 2 rooms covering 9, 10, 11, 12 and 13 April. The hotel offers comfortable rooms and is conveniently located near public transportation, making it easy to explore the city. It also has amenities such as a fitness center and a restaurant, providing a convenient and enjoyable stay during our trip.

The Trip – Preliminary Information

Travel to Amsterdam – Thursday 9th April

Leave house at 7.00am to get to Birmingham Airport for 7:30am. Flight departs at 9:20am and arrives in Amsterdam at 11:30am (local times). Take the Sprinter to Amsterdam Centraal and then walk to Centraal Station to pick up the number 14 bus to the Artis/ Holocaust Museum and the hotel is a two-minute walk from there. Check in to hotel and then free time for the rest of the day.

During the afternoon, we have tickets for the Museum Van Loon, on Keizersgracht. Museum van Loon is a 21 minute walk from the hotelSophie won't arrive till the evening and wasn't too interested in going to the

museum, so we will go without her and then meet up with her in the evening, when her Eurostar gets in.

Trip to Keukenhof – Friday 10th April

Breakfast: not yet planned in.But there are plenty of coffee shops around Overhoeksplein 51, 1031 KS Amsterdam, Netherlands where we will be getting the coach to Keukenhof, so we can get breakfast there before we get the coach.

Lunch: On the go at Keukenhof somewhere in the park. There are a number of cafes and restaurants in the park, so we can choose from those when we get there.

Dinner: not yet planned in. We will probably eat in Amsterdam when we get back from Keukenhof, but we can decide on the day where to eat.

We will travel to Keukenhof by coach. To get the coach, we have to travel to Overhoeksplein 51 and exchange our Get Your Guide voucher for the tickets.

The HopOn HopOff Holland tour to Keukenhof departs from This is Holland, Overhoeksplein 51 in Amsterdam. Please exchange your "GetYourGuide" voucher for your bus ticket and your official Keukenhof entrance ticket at the welcome desk.

To get to This is Holland, take the free ferry from platform F3 behind Central Station. The ferry shows direction “Buiksloterweg”. It is only a 3-minute ferry ride to the opposite side. When you get off the ferry, turn left. Look up and you will see a round building with the red, white and blue flag of Holland. This building is “This is Holland”. From the ferry, it’s a 3-minute walk.

We need to arrive at Overhoeksplein 51 ten minutes before our shuttle bus departure at 0945 (so 0935) and public transport will take approx. 37 mins from our hotel to get there.

At Keukenhof, we will have a few hours to explore the park and see the tulips, windmills and maybe the castle before returning to Amsterdam in the evening.

Free Day in Amsterdam – Saturday 11th April

This is a free day in Amsterdam, so we can explore the city at our leisure. There are a number of potential things to do;

Breakfast: Sophie is likely to be doing the Park Run at 9am. We can then meet up with her somewhere for brunch after that. There are plenty of cafes around the city centre, so we can choose from those when we get there.

Lunch: On the go, depending on what we decide to do.

Dinner: not yet planned in. We will probably eat in Amsterdam , but we can decide on the day where to eat.

- Upside down experience
- The Ice Bar
- Visit Begijnhof - small enclave of housing with oldest house in Amsterdam
- Canal boat trip (day or evening)

I am not personally interested in going into Anne

Frank's house but there are some recommended local cafes that overlook the house and are worth a visit, namely Cafe Winkel 43 (famous for its apple pie) and Cafe de Prins. Also, Google recommends:

- The Pancake Bakery: Located on Prinsengracht, it is a highly-rated, historic spot just steps away from Anne Frank's house.

  ,
- Cafe Kalkhoeven: A traditional, busy Dutch cafe popular for its location directly opposite the Westertoren.

Museum Day in Amsterdam – Sunday 12th April

This is our museum day in Amsterdam. We have two bookings:

- Van Gogh Museum 10:15 on Sunday 12 April
- Rijksmuseum, 2pm on Sunday 12 April

Breakfast: not yet planned in.

Lunch: In cafe at the Rijksmuseum (see below)?.

Dinner: not yet planned in. We will probably eat in Amsterdam , but we can decide on the day where to eat.

In between those two bookings, potentially we can have lunch at the Rijksmuseum cafe, which is a very nice cafe with a good menu and a great location in the museum gardens. We can also have a look around the museum shop, which has some nice souvenirs and gifts.

Second free day in Amsterdam – Monday 13th April

There are a number of other things that we could do during our trip to Amsterdam, but I have not yet made any firm plans for these. These include:

- Visit the Moco Museum - includes Banksy and other modern artists
- Visit the Heineken Experience, which is a tour of the Heineken brewery and includes tastings of their beers.
- Visit the Red Light District, which is a famous area of Amsterdam known for its nightlife and adult entertainment.
- Visit the Jordaan neighbourhood, which is a trendy area with lots of cafes, restaurants and shops.
- Visit the Vondelpark, which is a large park in the centre of Amsterdam that is popular for picnics, bike rides and outdoor activities.
- Day trips outside Amsterdam, for example to Delft

Return travel from Amsterdam – Tuesday 14th April

Our return flight from Amsterdam departs at 16:35 and arrives at 16:50 (local times). Em returns with us to Hampton and Sophie returns to London on the Eurostar. We will get a taxi from our hotel to the airport, which should take about 30 minutes. We will need to leave the hotel by 2:30pm to get to the airport in time for our flight.

Appendix 1 Personal Packing Checklist

For what it's worth, my personal holiday essentials list is included below. Adapt for your own needs, of course!

Holiday Essentials

Passport Details

N.B. Blood group added in pre Japan trip

Name on Passport	Passport No.	Expiry Date	Blood Group
John Brinley Cable	159455258	14 January 2036	AB+
Lesley Anne Cable	556517863	18 February 2029	O+
Sophie Vinetta Cable	575491003	11 January 2030	A+
Emily Beatrice Cable	154332742	16 April 2035	B+

Preparation

- Clear out travel backpack
- Charge up camera batteries
- Charge up juice-block
- Unload current camera memory cards
- Download any programmes to watch to iPad
- Sort out device charging leads – iPhone, iPad, FitBit, juice block
- USB charging plug
- Multi-way charging block
- Sunglasses and spare pair of ordinary glasses
- Cap (optional)
- Sort out documents: passport, travel documents, immunisation certificates
- Travel adapter
- Check and buy if necessary:
    - travel sickness tablets
    - insect repellent
    - travel-size toiletries

Packing

- Put USB and charging leads in protective Tupperware
- Put charging block in base of case
- Tablets for the trip – hip etc.
- Backpack:

    - throw-away fiction book
    - iPad + headphones
    - Travel sickness tablets
    - Small pack tissues / cleansing wipes
- Pack into carrier bags:
    - Underwear
    - Socks – incl. sports socks
    - Swim stuff*
    - Shirts + trousers / shorts
- Shoes + sandals (+ flip-flops*)
- Pyjamas – in outside case pocket.
- Pack toiletry bag:
    - Razor + blades
    - Shaving foam
    - Toothbrush head*?
    - Spray**
    - After bite + Savlon
    - Headache tablets
    - Hairbrush

Don't forget to weigh case – safe maximum is 20KG.
Camera (in backpack) is hand luggage

Note for neighbours

N.B.

* optional – depends on the holiday
** may purchase in Duty Free at airport
*? may be packed with family toiletry bag

Appendix 2 Best Hot Chocolate Cafes in Amsterdam

For an authentic hot chocolate experience in Amsterdam, Chocolaterie Pompadour and Chocolátl are widely considered the gold standards for quality and atmosphere. Both offer rich, decadent hot chocolate in a charming setting that captures the essence of Amsterdam's café culture. If you're looking for the current "viral" trend, MOCA is the go-to spot for its signature toasted marshmallow rim.

- **Chocolaterie Pompadour**: This historic café is renowned for its luxurious hot chocolate, made with high-quality cocoa and served in a cozy, vintage setting. It’s a perfect place to indulge in a rich, velvety cup of hot chocolate while soaking in the old-world charm of Amsterdam.

  N.B.: Every cup is allegedly served with a financier (a small almond cake).
  Address: Gracchtengordel 2, 1015 RP Amsterdam, Netherlands
- **Chocolátl**: Known for its artisanal approach to chocolate, Chocolátl offers a variety of hot chocolate flavors, including classic, spicy, and even savory options. The café’s modern and

stylish ambiance makes it a great spot for chocolate lovers looking for a unique twist on the traditional hot chocolate experience.

N.B.: They offer "Chocolabs" (guided tastings) and source single-origin bars from around the world.
Address: Haarlemmerstraat 36, 1013 ER Amsterdam, Netherlands

- **MOCA**: This trendy café has gained popularity for its innovative take on hot chocolate, featuring a signature toasted marshmallow rim that adds an extra layer of flavor and texture. MOCA's contemporary vibe and Instagram-worthy presentation make it a must-visit for those seeking the latest hot chocolate craze in Amsterdam.

  N.B.: A rich 65% cocoa drink featuring a rim of golden-brown toasted marshmallow cream finished with a blowtorch.
  Address: Eerste van der Helststraat 27, 1073 XG Amsterdam, Netherlands

Whether you prefer the classic or the trendy, these three cafes are must–visit destinations for hot chocolate lovers in Amsterdam.

Others

- **De Drie Graefjes**: This charming café is known for its delicious hot chocolate, which is made with a blend of rich cocoa and creamy milk. The cozy atmosphere and friendly service make it a great spot to relax and enjoy a comforting cup of hot chocolate.

  Address: Rokin 130, 1012 LB Amsterdam, Netherlands
- **Vlaamsch Broodhuys**: While primarily known for its artisanal bread, Vlaamsch Broodhuys also serves a delightful hot chocolate that pairs perfectly with their freshly baked goods. The café's warm and inviting ambiance makes it an ideal place to enjoy a sweet treat and a cup of hot chocolate.

  Address: Multiple locations across Amsterdam

Appendix 3 Potential day trips

We have two potential day trips planned during our stay in Amsterdam.

The first is a visit to the picturesque village of Volendam, which is located about 20 kilometers north of Amsterdam. Volendam is known for its charming harbor, traditional Dutch architecture, and vibrant fishing culture. Visitors can stroll along the waterfront, enjoy fresh seafood at local restaurants, and explore the quaint shops selling traditional Dutch crafts and souvenirs. It’s a great destination for those looking to experience authentic Dutch culture and enjoy scenic views of the IJsselmeer lake.

To get to Volendam from Amsterdam, you can take a bus or a ferry. The bus is a convenient option, with regular services departing from Amsterdam Central Station and taking approximately 30-40 minutes to reach Volendam. Alternatively, you can take a ferry from Amsterdam to Volendam, which offers a scenic route across the IJsselmeer and takes about 1 hour. Both options provide a comfortable and enjoyable way to reach this charming Dutch village for a day of exploration and relaxation.

The second potential trip is to the historic city of Delft, which is located about 80 kilometers southwest of Amsterdam. Delft is famous for its beautiful canals, historic architecture, and its association with the Dutch painter Johannes Vermeer. Visitors to Delft can explore the charming city center, visit the Royal Delft factory to see the iconic blue and white pottery being made, and admire the stunning Nieuwe Kerk (New Church) with its impressive tower offering panoramic views of the city. Delft also has a rich history, with many museums and landmarks that provide insight into its past as a major trading city during the Dutch Golden Age.

To get to Delft from Amsterdam, you can take a direct train from Amsterdam Central Station, which takes approximately 1 hour. Trains run frequently throughout the day, making it easy to plan a day trip to this picturesque city and explore its rich cultural heritage and charming atmosphere.